

Session 27: Isaac's Marriage to Rebekah

Key Takeaways

- After Avraham receives his first possession in the land, the story turns to the problem that Yitskhaq alone cannot solve.
- Biblical narrative shows us God's providence at work through the "happenings" of the story.
- Rivqah is like the Avraham of the next generation, leaving her home and family to see God's promise secured.

Macro Design Genesis 24

Genesis 24:1-28

Avraham, His Servant, the Oath, and the Journey Back to Mesopotamia

Genesis 24:1-9

Avraham Makes Servant Swear an Oath to Take a Wife for Yitskhaq From His Family

- 24:1 "Yahweh had blessed Avraham in everything"
- 24:4 "Go to my land and my family and take a wife for my son"
- 24:5 "What if she will not come after me?"

Genesis 24:10-28

The Servant's Journey to the City of Nakhor

- 24:10 "And the servant took ten camels and he went ... and kneeled them by a well "
- 24:10-14 The servant prays to God about a test: "Oh Yahweh, Elohim of my master Avraham"
- 24:15-21 The prayer is granted: test fulfilled
- 24:22-28 The servant praises God: "Blessed be Yahweh, Elohim of my master Avraham"

Genesis 24:29-51

The Servant Retells the Story of Yahweh's Faithfulness

Genesis 24:29-33

Lavan Hears the Words that Rivqah Says About the Words of the Servant

Genesis 24:34-49

The Servant **Speaks His Words**

- **24:34-41** The servant recounts his conversation with Avraham (see v. 1-9)
- **24:42-28** The servant recounts his meeting with Rivqah (see v. 10-14)
- **24:49** The servant asks Lavan and Betuel to make a decision

Genesis 24:50-51

Lavan: “**The word** has come out from Yahweh ... let it be as he has **spoken**.”

Genesis 24:52-67

Rivqah, the Blessing, and the Journey Back to Canaan

Genesis 24:52-61

The Servant Asks Rivqah, Together They Journey Back to Canaan

- **24:52-54a** The servant gives Rivqah many treasures
- **24:54b-58** Rivqah agrees to go with the servant
- **24:59-61** “**And they blessed Rivqah** : 'May you become thousands of multitudes!'"
- **24:61** “**And Rivqah arose ... and she went after the man ... and he took her and he went.**”

Genesis 24:62-67

The Servant and Rivqah Arrive in Canaan and Meet Yitskhaq

- **24:62-64** The servant's return to Yitskhaq at a well
 - **24:63** “And Yitskhaq came from **the 'Well** of Life of Seeing' ... and **camels** were coming”
- **24:65** Dialogue
- **24:66-67** Yitskhaq marries Rivqah and finds comfort

Genesis 24:1-67. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 24:1-9

¹ Now, **Avraham** was old,
going on in days,
and Yahweh had **blessed (ברך)** **Avraham** in everything.

² **And Avraham said to his servant**,
the old one of his house,
who ruled over all that belonged to him,
“Please **place your hand under my thigh (ידך)**,

³ so I can make you **swear an oath** by **Yahweh**,
the Elohim of the skies and the Elohim of the land:

You will not take a woman for my son from the daughters of the Canaanites,
in whose midst I am dwelling.

⁴ Rather, **to my land and to my family** you will go,
and **you will take a woman for my son, for Yitskhaq.**"

⁵ **And the servant said to him,**

"Perhaps the woman will not be willing to go after me to this land.
Should I return your son to the land which you came out from there?"

⁶ **And Avraham said to him,**

"Keep watch of yourself, so that you **don't return my son to there.**

⁷ **Yahweh the Elohim of the skies,**

who took me from the house of my father and from **the land of my family**,
and who spoke to me,
and who **swore an oath** to me, saying,

"To your seed I will give this land."

he will send his messenger before you,
so you can take a woman for my son from there.

⁸ And **if the woman is not willing to go after you from there,**
then you are innocent from **this oath**.
Only **do not return my son to there.**

⁹ And the servant **placed his hand under the thigh (יד)** of Avraham his master,
and he **swore an oath** to him about this matter.

Genesis 24:1-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Macro Design Genesis 24:10-28

Genesis 24:10-14

- **24:10** The servant rides camels over the rivers **to a well**
- **24:11** The servant with his camels **by a well** outside the city
- **24:12-14** **The servant's prayer to Yahweh**
 - **"O Yahweh, Elohim of my master Avraham."**
 - **The test: Meet woman at the well > She gives a drink and waters the camels**

Genesis 24:15-21

- **24:15-16** A woman appears at the well: Rivqah, Avraham's great-niece
- **24:17-20** The test fulfilled: She gives drink and waters the camels
- **24:21** The servant watches and waits to see if Yahweh has made his way successful

Genesis 24:22-28

- **24:22** The servant gives treasures to Rivqah
- **24:23-25** Dialogue between servant and Rivqah
 - **24:23** Servant: (a) Whose daughter are you? (b) Is there a place to stay?
 - **24:24** Rivqah: (a) I am daughter of Betuel, born to Nakhor
 - **24:25** Rivqah: (b) We have a place to stay
- **24:26-27** The servant bows and worships Yahweh
 - "Blessed be Yahweh, Elohim of my master Avraham."
 - Yahweh had led me on the way to the house of my master's brother."

Genesis 24:10-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 24:10-67

¹⁰ And the servant took ten camels from the camels of his master and he went and all the good of his master was in his hand and he got up and he went to the land of Aram- Naharayim (= "Aram of Two Rivers"), to the city of Nakhor.

¹¹ And he made the camels kneel outside the city, at a well of water, at the time of evening, at the time when the women who get water come out.

¹² And he said,

A "Yahweh, Elohim of my master Avraham, Please make it happen today before me, and act with loyal-love toward my master Avraham.

¹³ Look, I am standing at the spring of the water, and the daughters of the men of the city are coming out to get water.

¹⁴ And may it be that the young woman to whom I say,

B "Please lower your jar, so I can drink." and she says,

"Drink! And I will also give drink to your camels!"

May she be the one you've decided for your servant, for Isaac.

A' And by means of her, **I will know** that **you have acted with loyal-love toward my master.**"

15 And it came about, before he finished speaking,

a that look, **Rivqah** came out,

b who was born for **Betuel son of Milkah**,

b' wife of **Nakhor, the brother of Avraham**,

a' and **her jar** was on her shoulder.

a 16 And the **young woman** **was good to see, very much**,

b a virgin,

b' and a man had not known her,

a' and she went down to the spring and filled **her jar** and she brought it up,

a 17 and the servant ran to meet her,

b and he said,

"Please, may I **swallow a bit of water** from your jar?"

b' **and she said**,

18 "**Drink**, my master."

a' **and she hurried** and lowered **her jar** in her hand

and she let him **drink**,

19 and **she finished** letting him **drink**,

b' **and she said**,

"Also for **your camels**, let me get **water**,

until they are finished **drinking**."

a 20 **And she hurried** and emptied **her jar** into the **water-trough**,

a' **and she ran** again to the **well** to get **water**,

and she got **water** for all his **camels**.

21 And **the man was staring at her**,

being silent, **so he could know** **if Yahweh had made his way successful or not**.

22 And it came about when **the camels** finished **drinking**,

that the man took a gold nose-ring, a half-Shekel in weight,

and two bracelets on her hands, ten gold was their weight,

23 and he said,

"**Whose daughter are you** ?

a Please tell me!

Is there a place for us to stay in the house of your father?"

24 And she said to him,

"A daughter of **Betuel** I am,

the son of **Milkah**,

h

whom **she birthed for Nakhor**."

25 And she said to him,

a' b' "We have much straw and fodder, and also **a place to stay** .

26 And the man bowed in worship to Yahweh, and said,

27 "May **Yahweh be blessed, Elohim of my master Avraham**,
who has not abandoned **his loyal-love and faithfulness with my master** .

As for me, **Yahweh has guided me on the way** to **the house of the brother of my master** ."

28 And the young woman ran

and she reported to the **house of her mother** about these words.

Genesis 24:1-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

29 Now, **Rivqah had a brother**,

and his name was Lavan,

a and Lavan ran to **the man outside the city, to the spring** .

b 30 And it came about when he saw the nose-ring and the bracelets on the hands of **his sister**,

b' and when he heard the **spoken-words** of Rivqah **his sister**, saying,

a' "This is what **the man spoke** to me,"

that he went to **the man** and look, he was standing by **his camels** , **by the spring** .

31 And he said,

"**Come** , **blessed one of Yahweh** !

Why do you stand outside?

I have prepared **the house** and a place for **the camels** !"

32 And the man **came** into **the house** ,

and he opened up **the camels** ,

and he gave **straw and fodder** to **the camels** ,

and **water** for washing his feet and the feet of the men with him,

33 and there was set before him **food for eating** ,

and he said ,

"I will not **eat food** until I **speak** my **words** ."

And he said ,

"**Speak** !"

34 And he said,

"A servant of Avraham I am.

35 And **Yahweh has blessed** my master very much,

and he has become great ,

and he has given to him

flocks and herds
and silver and gold
and male and female servants
and camels and donkeys,

36 and Sarah, the wife of my master, has birthed for him **a son**, after she has become old,
and he gave to him everything which belongs to him.

37 And my master made me **swear an oath**, saying,

‘**You will not take a woman for my son**
from the daughters of the Canaanites,
in whose land I am dwelling.

38 Rather, you will go to **the house of my father**,
and to my clan,
and **you will take a woman for my son**!’

39 And I said to my master,

‘Perhaps **the woman** will not come after me.’

40 And he said to me,

‘**Yahweh**, whom I have walked before his face,
he will send his messenger with you,
and he will make your way successful,

and **you will take a woman for my son**, from my clan, and from the house of my father.

41 Then **you will be innocent from my oath**,
because you will have gone to my clan.

And if they don’t give you,

then **you will be innocent from my oath**.’

42 And I went today to the spring,
and I said,

‘**Yahweh, Elohim of my master Avraham**,
if you would **please make successful my way** upon which I walk,

43 look, I am standing by a **spring of water**.

And may it come about that the young woman who comes out to get **water**,
and to whom I say,

“Please, give me a little **water** to **drink** from **your jar**.”

44 and then she says to me,

“Both you I will give to **drink**, and I will also get **water** for your camels.”

May that be the woman whom **Yahweh has decided for** the son of my master.’

45 I had just finished speaking to my heart,
and look, Rivqah came out!

And **her jar** was on her shoulder,

a and she went down to the **spring** and got **water**,
b and I said to her,
‘Please, give me a **drink**.’
a’ 46 And she hurried and brought down **her jar** from upon her,
and she said,
b’ ‘**Drink**! And I will also **water** your camels.’
and I **drank**, and also she **watered** the camels.

47 And I asked her and I said,
‘Whose **daughter** are you?’
And she said,
‘The **daughter** of Betuel,
the son of Nakhor,
whom Milkah birthed for him.’
48 And I bowed in worship to Yahweh,
and **I blessed Yahweh the Elohim of my master Avraham,**
who guided me on the way of faithfulness,
to take **the daughter of the brother of my master** for his son.

49 And now, if you all are going to act with **loyal-love and faithfulness** to my master, **tell me!**
And if not, **tell me!**
So I can turn to the right or to the left!"

50 And Lavan answered, and Betuel, and they said,
“**The spoken-word has gone out from Yahweh!**
We are not able to **speak a word** to you, bad or good!
51 Look, Rivqah is before you: take and go!
And **she can become a wife for the son of your master,**
just as Yahweh has spoken a word.”

Genesis 24:29-51. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

52 And it came about when the servant of Avraham heard their **spoken-words**,
then he bowed onto the ground in worship of Yahweh.
53 And the servant brought out articles of silver and articles of gold and clothes,
and he gave to **Rivqah (רבקה)**,
and he gave precious gifts to her brother and to her mother.
54 And they ate and they drank,
he and the men with him,
and they stayed the night.

And they got up in the morning,

a **and he said,**

"**Send me off to my master**!"

55 **And they said,** her brother and her mother,

b "Let the young woman dwell with us a few days, or ten;
after that **she can go**."

56 **And he said** to them,

"Do not make me delay.

a'

Yahweh has made my way successful .

Send me off so I can go to my master ."

57 **And they said,**

b' " **Let us call** the young woman,
and we can inquire what she says."

58 And **they called Rivqah**

b" **and they said to her,**

"**Will you go** with this man?"

a" **And she said,**

"**I will go** ."

59 And **they sent Rivqah (רבקה)** their sister and her nursemaid,
and the servant of Abraham and his men,

60 and they **blessed (ברך) Rivqah (רבקה)**,
and they said to her,

"Our sister, may you become into thousands of **ten-thousands (רבבה)**,
and may your seed possess the gate of its haters."

61 And she arose, **Rivqah (רבקה)** and her young women,

and **they rode (רכב)** upon the camels,

and **they went** after the man

and the servant took **Rivqah (רבקה)** and **he went** .

62 Now, Yitskhaq was going from the entrance of **Beer** -Lakhai-Roi (" **Well** of the Living One Who Sees Me")

and he was dwelling in the land of the Negev,

63 and Yitskhaq went out **to urinate in the field** as it turned to evening,

and **he lifted his eyes and he saw**

and look, **camels** coming;

64 and **Rivqah** **lifted her eyes and she saw** Yitskhaq,

and she fell off her **camel** .

65 And she said to the servant,
 "Who is this man,
 who is **walking in the field** to meet us?"
 And the servant said,
 "He is my master."
 And she took a veil and she covered herself.

66 And the servant recounted to Yitskhaq all the things that he did,
 67 and **Yitskhaq brought her (ויבאה)** into the tent of **Sarah his mother** ,
 and he took **Rivqah** ,
 and **she became for him a wife** ,
 and **he loved her (ויאהבה)**
 and Yitskhaq was comforted after the death of **his mother** .

Genesis 24:52-67. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Rivqah: Avraham's Counterpart in the Next Generation

Sarah's death signals the passing away of Avraham's generation. How will the next generation participate in the ongoing covenant promises of Yahweh? For Avraham, the question of seed is paramount. The chosen son has no counterpart, even though Avraham finds himself in a state of blessing. This story foregrounds the miraculous nature of Rivqah's entry into Avraham's family, and it also highlights her own faithfulness by portraying her as a female counterpart to Avraham.

Avraham's Journey of Faith	Rivqah's Journey of Faith
Gen. 12:1 Avraham leaves "his land and family (ארץ + מולדת)."	Gen. 24:7 Avraham's servant brings Rivqah from "the house of my father, and from the land of my family (ארץ מולדתי)."
Gen. 11:31, 12:4-6 He sojourns from Mesopotamia to go to Canaan.	She sojourns from Mesopotamia, by Aram of Two-Rivers (Gen. 24:10), to go to the land of Canaan (Gen. 24:61)
Gen. 11:29 He leaves behind Nakhor his brother and his wife Milkah.	Gen. 24:15, 24 She leaves behind her father Betuel son of Nakhor and her grandmother Milkah.
<i>Avraham and Rivqah.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Avraham's Journey of Faith

Gen. 12:1-2 Avraham leaves because of God's promise of blessing: "I will make you a great nation."

*"Blessing" occurs 5x in Gen. 12:1-3

Rivqah's Journey of Faith

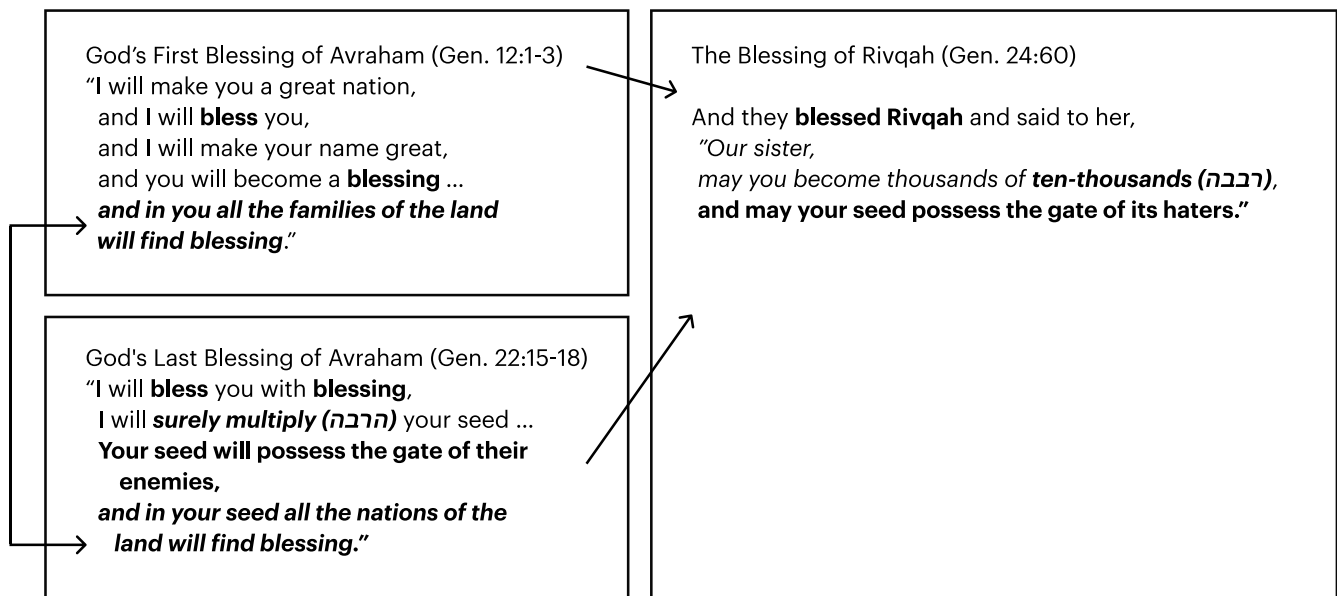
Gen. 24:60 Rivqah leaves with a promise of blessing: "May you become thousands of ten-thousands!"

*"Blessing" occurs 7x in Gen. 24 (v. 1, 11 "kneel," 27, 31, 35, 48, 60)

Avraham and Rivqah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Blessings From Beginning to End

Rivqah's family announces a blessing over her as she leaves Mesopotamia and surrenders herself wholly to God's purposes. Rivqah's blessing connects to God's first blessing to Avraham when he left Mesopotamia ([Gen. 11-12](#)) and to God's final blessing to Avraham when he surrendered Yitskhaq over to God ([Gen. 22](#)).



Blessings From Beginning to End. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Rivqah, Bride of Eden

Many hyperlinks in this story link back to the provision of a wife for the human in [Genesis 2](#) and to the provision of the ark for Noah in [Genesis 6-8](#). In both cases, God provides for the chosen lineage at precisely the moment when its future is in jeopardy.

God's Provision of a Wife for Adam	God's Provision of a Wife for Yitskhaq
Gen. 2:18-20 The human is alone and cannot carry out God's will to be fruitful and multiply, and no counterparts are found among the animals.	Gen. 24:1-9 Yitskhaq cannot carry on the promised lineage alone, as he needs a counterpart to be fruitful and multiply, but none will be found among the Canaanites.
Gen. 2:10, 21-25 In the garden, by the stream that will become "rivers" (נהרים), and with the animals, God splits the human and builds (בנה) a counterpart, his wife.	Gen. 24:10-21 Past the land of "two rivers" (נהרים), by a spring/well of water, with the camels, God provides a female counterpart for Yitskhaq to be his wife.
Gen. 2:22 "And Yahweh Elohim brought her to (ויבאה אל) the human."	Gen. 24:67 "And [Yitskhaq] brought her into his tent (ויבאה ... האהלה)"
Gen. 2:23 "And the human said, 'This (זאת) time: bone from my bone, flesh from my flesh, this one (לזאת) will be called wo-man because from man she was taken.'"	Gen. 24:65 "And [Rivqah] said, 'Who is the man (האיש), this one (הלזה) ...?'"
Gen. 2:24 "A man will leave his father and his mother and cling to his wife, and the two will become one flesh."	Gen. 24:38 "Go to the house of my father, and take a wife for my son." Gen. 24:67 "And Yitskhaq brought her into the tent of Sarah his mother, and Rivqah became his wife ..."
God's Provision, Adam and Yitskhaq. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

God's Provision of the Ark for Noah and the Animals	God's Provision of a Wife for Yitskhaq
Gen. 6:14-22 God tells Noah to build a place of refuge from the flood, the ark (התבה).	Gen. 24:15 The servant goes to get a wife for Avraham's son, and comes to the house (הביתה) of Avraham's brother.
The animals come, two by two, male and female, each with his wife (אשה / איש, Gen. 7:2) and "enter into the ark" (Gen. 7:9) where they are given food for eating (Gen. 6:21).	Gen. 24:32 The servant's 10 animals come with him, and as "the man enters into the house," they are given food.
God's Provision, Noah and Yitskhaq. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

God's Provision of the Ark for Noah and the Animals	God's Provision of a Wife for Yitskhaq
Gen. 7 Noah and his wife pass through the waters of the flood with the animals.	Gen. 24:61 The servant and Yitskhaq's future wife cross the rivers of Mesopotamia with their animals.
<i>God's Provision, Noah and Yitskhaq. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Notice that the story of Ruth is aware of these connections between Genesis 2, 6-8, and 24, and the story draws upon the entire design pattern by selecting vocabulary from strategic moments in the stories.

Reflection Question

How does the biblical narrative tell us God is at work in Genesis 24?